

03. Cancer Diagnosis

Introduction

Cancer diagnosis involves evaluating symptoms, medical history, physical examination, imaging tests, laboratory tests, and tissue sampling to confirm the presence and type of cancer.

Medical History and Physical Examination

Doctors review symptoms, family history, lifestyle factors, and perform a physical examination for lumps, swelling, skin changes, or enlarged lymph nodes.

Blood Tests

Blood tests evaluate overall health and may include complete blood count, liver and kidney function tests, and selected tumor markers. Blood tests alone usually cannot diagnose cancer.

Imaging Tests

Common imaging tests include X-rays, ultrasound, CT scans, MRI scans, PET scans, and mammography. These help locate tumors and determine their size and spread.

Biopsy

A biopsy removes a small sample of tissue for microscopic examination. It is often the most reliable way to confirm a cancer diagnosis.

Endoscopy

Endoscopy allows doctors to examine the inside of organs using a flexible camera. Procedures include colonoscopy, bronchoscopy, and upper GI endoscopy.

Cancer Staging

After diagnosis, staging determines the extent of disease and helps guide treatment planning.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can blood tests detect cancer? Sometimes they provide clues, but a biopsy is usually needed. Is every lump cancer? No. Many lumps are benign, but persistent or growing lumps should be evaluated by a healthcare professional.

Summary

Early diagnosis improves treatment options and outcomes. Anyone with persistent or concerning symptoms should seek medical evaluation.